

DESIGNER

COCO CHANEL

Credited with inventing everything from the suntan to the little black dress, “Coco” Chanel (1883–1971) was one of a number of designers, including Jean Patou, who set the tone for informal womenswear. She was a towering fashion figure, expertly anticipating the post-World War I spirit, representing the modernist woman, and adding weight to many trends. Her 1920s and 30s womenswear developed a cleverly “simple” look that chimed with the sober functionalism of wartime clothes. It embraced relaxed Chanel suits in jersey and tweed, as well as streamlined shift chemises and the LBD (Little Black Dress), costume jewellery, wide-bottomed trousers, and signature accessories.

Capitalizing on her own boyish figure, Chanel embraced the less constricted approach, creating clothes that were comfortable and easy for “new” women to wear. Her own appearance and lifestyle personified modernist ideals, providing powerful publicity and giving her an enduring, iconic status.

Making the right connections

After a hard start in life, support from wealthy male admirers helped Chanel establish a Parisian millinery business in 1910, followed by shops in the fashionable beach resorts of Deauville and Biarritz. She began experimenting with menswear styles and making women’s garments from jersey, a soft, easily draped fabric. By 1919 she had a booming business in Paris.

The 1920s established her staple range of pullovers and loose or cardigan jackets, short skirts, and simple blouses. There were fancier dresses for evening but still with a lean, stylish simplicity. Acclaim followed. Practicality and comfort

were key to Chanel’s relaxed mode – encapsulated in the sensibly placed pocket, for example. More importantly, Chanel clothes spoke of youthful effortlessness, so different from pre-war styles, but with high price tags; her market was the leisured wealthy.

Chanel promoted an often muted palette of grey, black, white, and navy, and fed a major craze for beige. Enlivening additions included gilt buttons and gilt-chained bags, as well as costume jewellery, which under her influence became not just acceptable but desirable.

She pioneered mixing real gems with fake ones – artificial pearls were a favourite.

Closing her couture house during World War II, Chanel (now in her 70s) relaunched herself in 1954.

Her reinvented simple skirt suit with braid-trimmed collarless jacket was an enormous success, especially in the US, where Jackie Onassis was a high-profile 1960s fan of the boxy ensemble and pearls. Chanel’s enduring appeal is thanks partly to loose lines that suit a wide variety of women and partly to her beautifully perfectionist finish, while her separates have promoted the all-important concept of the mix-and-match, investment capsule wardrobe.

Reinventing the look – Lagerfeld

Chanel was still overseeing her collections when she died, in her 80s, in 1971. The couture house continued and in 1978 the first prêt-à-porter (ready-to-wear) line was launched. In 1983 Karl Lagerfeld became head of design, raising the brand’s profile globally and promoting cult use of the Chanel logo. That he found so many fresh ways to mine Chanel concepts proves that Coco had tapped into a timeless purism. Many designers have drawn on her approach, from Claire McCardell to Betty Jackson.

**△ TIMELESS ALLURE**

Effortless chic and an air of enduring youth came naturally to Chanel and were key elements of the clothes she designed.

**◁ THE CLASSIC SUIT**

Still going strong in the 21st century, the Chanel suit with its collarless jacket, relaxed style, and easy-to-wear fabric is instantly recognizable.

TIMELINE

1883 Born Gabrielle Bonheur Chanel, in Saumur, France

1910 Opens hat shop in Paris

◁ 1918–19 After running shops in Deauville and Paris, moves business to 31 rue Cambon, Paris, selling ensembles and separates. It remains there today

1921 Launches her fragrance Chanel No. 5

◁ 1930 Goes to Hollywood to design film costumes for United Artists stars such as Gloria Swanson and evening dresses

1939 Closes her couture house

1953–54 Relaunched and reinvents pre-war ideas to produce a classic collarless suit for the modern age

1971 Dies in Paris, aged 87

1983 Karl Lagerfeld takes over Chanel haute couture (1983) and prêt-à-porter (1984)